Facing Tribulation

Paul sends Timothy to a suffering church — to establish and encourage them — and finds his own life bound up with their standing firm.

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Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

From Berea to Corinth

Introduction · The background in Acts 17–18

A

Berea

Paul forced to leave; brothers escort him

Acts 17

B

Athens

Paul stays alone; sends Timothy back

3:1–2

C

Thessalonica

Timothy establishes and encourages the church

3:2–5

D

Corinth

Silas and Timothy find Paul (Acts 18:5)

Timothy's report · 3:6

E

The letter

Written from Corinth, looking back

1 Thessalonians

Paul could scarcely bear not knowing how they were doing. They had endured all kinds of tribulation; he had been chased out. So he sent Timothy back to find out how the young church was making out.

Why Timothy — and why he went

1 Thessalonians 3:2 · I.B — The proposal

The messenger chosen

διάκονος minister · G1249

- Our brother
- Minister of God
- Fellow laborer in the gospel

A full commendation for a young man — someone the church already knew and trusted.

The messenger charged

1. **To establish — στηρίζω**
   Make them firm: the faith believed (Jude 3) and their trust in it

2. **To encourage — παρακαλέω**
   Come alongside them in their afflictions, as the Paraclete does

3. **The two great needs**
   Something solid to stand on, and someone to stand with them

What the minister begins (stērizō, v.2), God completes (stērizō, v.13).

Appointed to this

1 Thessalonians 3:3–5 · I.C–D — The petition and the plan

Not shaken · v.3
σαίνω · κεῖμαι shaken · appointed

- Not “no tribulation” — but not shaken by it
- “We are appointed to this”
- Part of the calling, not a surprise

Foretold · v.4

- “We told you before” — again and again
- Taught before persecution came
- “Just as it happened, and you know”

The tempter · v.5
πειράζω to tempt · G3985

- No news is not good news
- Satan uses suffering to erode faith
- “Lest our labor might be in vain”

Suffering is not evidence that God has abandoned us; it is the predictable consequence of faithful gospel reception in a hostile world.

Good news from Thessalonica

1 Thessalonians 3:6–10 · II.A–C — Paul's consolation

v.6	Timothy's report: your faith and love; you long to see us	**εὐαγγελίζω** news as good as the gospel
v.7	In all our affliction we were comforted by your faith	**παρακαλέω** comfort is a two-way street
v.8	"For now we live, if you stand fast in the Lord"	**στήκω** their firmness, his vitality
v.9	What thanks can we render to God for you — all the joy	**—** God gets the credit
v.10	Praying night and day, exceedingly, to see you and complete your faith	**καταρτίζω** bring to full strength

Paul’s prayer: love, holiness, readiness

1 Thessalonians 3:11–13 · III.A–C — Paul’s craving

A

Direct our way

Father and Son named — one singular verb

v.11 · optative

B

Abound in love

To one another and to all — overflowing

περισσεύω · v.12

C

Hearts established

Blameless in holiness before God

ἀμέμπτως · v.13a

D

At His coming

With all His saints

παρουσία · v.13b

Love produces holiness; holiness makes the heart blameless at the coming of the Lord.

Blameless does not mean sinless — free of any reasonable charge, because sin is dealt with as God requires.

Coming for His saints — coming with them

1 Thessalonians 3:13b · III.C.2 — The return of the saints with the Lord

For His saints — the Rapture

- Christ comes for His church (4:13–18)
- The dead in Christ rise; the living are caught up
- Signless — at any moment

vs

With His saints — 3:13
παρουσία coming · G3952

- The public, triumphant Second Coming
- The saints who have gone to be with Christ come with Him
- Christians, not angels

Paul’s prayer is that when that day arrives, these believers would be found blameless — hearts established, lives marked by the holiness that comes from abounding love.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 3:1–13 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Verse 3 says believers are “appointed” to tribulation (keimai). What does this mean for how we interpret suffering — and how does it change our response?

2. Verse 8 says “we live, if you stand fast in the Lord.” Is this hyperbole, or does Paul mean it? What does it reveal about pastoral ministry?

Apply

Expect Tribulation; Prepare Others

Have one honest conversation with a younger believer about suffering — share verse 3: “we are appointed to this.”

Your Faithfulness Is a Lifeline

Message someone whose faith has strengthened you and tell them specifically what their steadfastness has meant.

In one line: Tribulation is part of the calling — so establish one another, stand fast together, and let love grow into holiness until He comes.